

GROWING UP IN Kolkata, Padmaja Ruparel picked up the strings of entrepreneurship early when she joined and then turned around her family's real estate business.

Later she shifted to Delhi when she got married. With an MBA under her belt, she started out as a career counsellor, but that didn't excite her much. In the 1990s, India's software space was taking off and Ruparel wanted to be a part of that. She joined a software services firm helmed by Saurabh Srivastava, who had co-founded Nasscom. Ruparel flourished under his mentorship, and was exposed to start-up founders and investors, thanks to Srivastava's connections with TiE and IVCA.

This eventually led her to setting up an investors' group along with her mentor and friends. Now known as Indian Angel Network (IAN), it was India's first group of angel investors. Today, IAN has close to 500 investors across 10 countries and a portfolio of

MONEY ANGEL

Padmaja Ruparel and her partners at Indian Angel Network have not just backed start-ups; they've created jobs as well

BY RICHA SHARMA



PADMAJA RUPAREL

62, Co-founder, Indian Angel Network

more than 200 companies in seven countries, spanning 17 sectors. The IAN group has invested over ₹900 crore in more than 250 start-ups so far, which are currently valued at over \$9 billion, and has created more than 100,000 jobs.

Ruparel, one of the first women in India to enter the investment space, returns to the BT MPW list after 2019. She says IAN is looking to invest in innovative solutions that solve real problems and is also making a bet on building some IP (intellectual property) portfolio firms. "It's high time for India to create its own, much deeper value IP, and we've looked at some of the emerging sectors like manufacturing tech, space tech and clean tech. We're looking at hardware electronics, semiconductors and biotech," she says. What next? She wants to contribute to national-focussed start-up innovation activities. **BT**

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WHAT ADVICE WOULD YOU LIKE TO GIVE TO YOUR YOUNGER SELF?

Do what makes you happy, again and again. Be with the same people again and again.

WHAT IS YOUR MANTRA FOR NAVIGATING CHALLENGES?

Be clinical in solving them, be empathetic, and focus on finding the solution rather than saying that I'm facing a problem